

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-09-02

1 . . . As a national community grows, the activities undertaken by its
2 members also increase in number and diversity. Some of these activities
3 will be initiated and administered by the bahá'í institutions. others will
4 fall in the realm of private initiative. when an initiative is in the form of a
5 private business venture undertaken by an individual or group, the institu-
6 tions of the faith have little reason to interfere with their daily affairs. only
7 if difficulties arise among the friends involved in such an enterprise, if their
8 activities could damage the good name of the faith, or if they misrepresent
9 their relationship to the faith, would a local or National Spiritual Assembly
10 intervene. bahá'í institutions, of course, applaud any effort by these private
11 ventures to apply the Teachings to their operations and to use their position in society
to further the interests of the faith. Spiritual Assemblies would
12 do well to offer them guidance, as requested or as circumstances require, and to help
them develop their potential for the advancement of the cause.

13 The private initiatives of believers need not, however, be limited to busi-
14 ness ventures. The laws of most societies allow for the establishment of non-
15 profit organizations which, while private, are subject to special regulations
16 and enjoy certain privileges. customarily a board of trustees is responsible
17 for all the affairs of such an organization and must ensure that its income is spent for
the purpose stipulated in its by-laws. This board also oversees the
18 functioning of the projects of the organization and the work of those who
19 are in charge of them. An increasing number of believers around the world are taking
advantage of this possibility and creating organizations dedicated
20 to the application of bahá'u'lláh's Teachings to the analysis and resolution
21 of important social and economic issues. The house of justice looks with
22 keen interest on this growing phenomenon in the bahá'í world. it only cau-
23 tions the friends that in establishing such organizations they should exercise care not
to become a burden on the institutions or unduly divert the contri-

24 butions of the believers from the essential and primary tasks of supporting the funds
of the faith and the activities of the institutions. it expects them

25 to conduct their affairs according to b ahá'í moral and ethical principles.167 .1

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169 57A question that often arises in relation to private organizations dedicated

170 to social and economic development is whether they are “b ahá'í” or not.

171 Such a question cannot be answered by a simple “yes” or “no.” clearly,

172 the fact that they have their own management structures puts them in a

173 different category from projects and organizations administered by bahá'í

174 institutions. in that sense they are not “b ahá'í” enterprises. in another sense,

175 to the extent that they are owned and directed by bahá'ís and strive to

176 apply the Teachings and serve the purposes of the cause, they may indeed

177 be regarded as “b ahá'í.” in referring to these organizations, we must avoid

178 giving the impression that participating in their projects does not constitute

179 legitimate service to the cause. otherwise sincere and devoted believers will

180 be discouraged from engaging in activities that are “b ahá'í” in nature. . . .

Department of tHe secretariat

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Recitation of the Prayer for the Dead

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]